

Viral STDs

Sexually transmitted diseases (STDs), also known as sexually transmitted infections (STIs), can be spread by vaginal, oral, or anal sex. STDs can have a variety of causes, among them viral infections.

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Viral STDs

A virus is a microorganism that multiplies inside the cells of other living organisms, and can cause serious harm. Unlike bacteria and parasites, viruses can't survive away from a host cell. They need host cells inside which they multiply. Viruses can enter the body from the environment or through contact with other people.

	Causes	Symptoms	Diagnosis	Treatment
Genital herpes	Genital herpes is caused by the herpes simplex virus (HSV), which can be spread by skin contact. HSV remains dormant (inactive) most of the time. Some triggers, such as illness, stress, or alcohol, reactivate the virus, causing blisters to develop. It is highly contagious, especially when a person has sores.	Small, painful blisters, or sores usually develop, which may cause itching or tingling, or make it painful to urinate.	A doctor or nurse will diagnose genital herpes based on visible symptoms.	There is no cure for genital herpes, but the symptoms can usually be controlled using antiviral medicines.
Hepatitis B	This is an infection of the liver caused by a virus spread through bodily fluids. Most often spread by unprotected sex, hepatitis B can also be spread by blood and bodily fluids; for example, by a mother to her newborn baby, injecting drugs, unclean tattoo or body piercing equipment, or sharing infected toothbrushes or razors.	Symptoms can include painful sores around the genital and anal area, nose, and mouth (cold sores).	Hepatitis B can be serious, so it's important to get medical advice if there is a possibility of infection. Hepatitis B is diagnosed with a blood test.	There is a vaccine for hepatitis B for those most at risk. Treatment varies based on how long it's been since the person was first exposed to the virus. After six months, the infection is incurable, but medicines are available to keep the virus under control and reduce the risk of liver damage.
HPV (genital warts)	It is spread by skin-to-skin contact.	Small, fleshy growths, bumps, or skin changes can appear on or around the genital or anal area. It can lead to cancerous growths. Usually HPV is painless, but it may cause itching, redness, or occasionally bleeding.	Diagnosed with a simple examination by a doctor or nurse, possibly using a magnifying lens.	It's treated with creams or by freezing the warts (cryotherapy). Vaccinations are offered to females age 12–13 against HPV because it is the main cause of cancer of the cervix (neck of the womb).